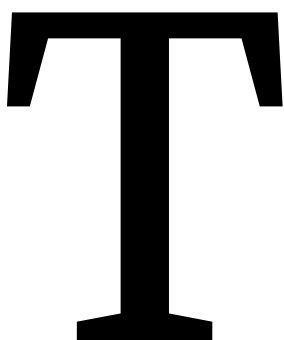


“The central theme of the reforms is to **protect policyholders’ interests**”

Debasish Panda, Chairperson of Irdai, talks about what the insurance regulator would need to do to make it easier for insurance companies to serve customers better

PHOTOS BY KRISHNENDU HALDER

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The Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) is on a mission to revamp and reform the insurance sector in the country and increase penetration. Irdai Chairperson Debasish Panda, 61, says the regulator’s emphasis is on lighter regulations and a consultative approach. In an email interaction with *Business Today’s Teena Jain Kaushal*, Panda shares insights on the sector, the changes planned and the way ahead. Edited excerpts:

Q: The insurance sector has seen several reforms in the recent past. What are your plans moving forward?

A: Irdai is actively working towards creating an attractive landscape in India’s insurance sector, aligning with the country’s resilient economy and

business-friendly market. The primary objective of these efforts is to ensure the availability, accessibility, and affordability of insurance for all citizens and businesses. The initial reforms focussed on facilitating product launches, flexible capital raising, efficient management of expenses, expanding distribution channels, and enhancing reinsurance accessibility and facilitating setting up of new entities.

Moving forward, Irdai is striving to adopt a principle-based regulatory regime and implement lighter regulations, following a consultative approach. The proposed amendments to insurance laws include rationalised capital requirements, composite registration, one-time registration for intermediaries, value-added services by insurers, sale of other financial products, etc. Additionally, initiatives such as an e-marketplace protocol, localised women-centric distribution force, and simplified benefit-based products are being considered to further enhance accessibility, availability, and affordability. These reforms are expected to significantly contribute to insurance penetration, promoting a more inclusive and robust insurance ecosystem in India.

Q: Could you provide a broad framework of proposed e-marketplace Bima Sugam and how it will impact the industry’s dynamics?

A: A dynamic and evolving society requires faster and convenient solutions. The demand is for easy accessibility, efficient communication, enhanced customer engagement, prompt issue resolution, and valuable data insights. Bima Sugam, the contemplated insurance e-marketplace, is a step in this direction. The aim is to integrate it with India Stack to ensure